EL SALVADOR (23 November)

Hurricane “Mitch “ left about 240 casualties and by 15 November, more than 235 persons were still missing. The affected population is estimated about 84 000 persons, of which 10 370 have totally lost their homes or suffered severe damage in their properties. Enormous damage to the country infrastructure is reported. The agricultural sector was also severely affected, particularly the departments of Usulután, Morazán and the southern parts of the department of San Miguel. Some villages on the Pacific coast were also seriously affected by the floods. Harvesting of the 1998 first season cereal crops was well advanced when the hurricane struck and some planting of the second crop had been initiated. No detailed assessment of damage has yet been made, but extensive damage is reported to fields of standing crops in the aforementioned areas, which are some of the most economically depressed zones in the country. Early estimates indicate that possibly as much as 80 percent of the maize grown in these areas have been lost. Other important crops for the affected population, such as sorghum and beans, are reported to have been seriously damaged. Important coffee plantations, a main agricultural export, have been seriously affected. Preliminary estimates indicate that about 10 percent of the 1998/99 coffee crop has been severely affected. The important sugar cane crop is also reported to be considerably affected. Damage has also been incurred to the foreign exchange earner cotton crop. Food assistance will be immediately provided for 60 000 people for six months from the large scale assistance is being provided by the international community. A detailed assessment of damage is in the process of being initiated for the rehabilitation of the agricultural activities in the affected areas.

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